

Inventing the wheel

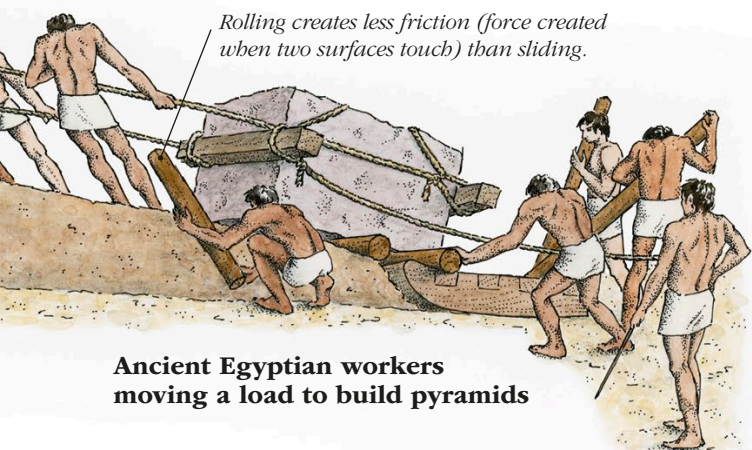
The wheel is one of the most important things ever invented, although no one knows who first thought of it. Originally, wheels helped potters to make perfectly round pots. Then, around 3500 BCE, someone had the idea of using them to move people and materials around on land. The wheel completely changed everyday life, making it easier for people to travel, trade, and work.

Wooden peg
keeps the axle
in place.

ROLLER AND SLEDGE

Before the wheel, heavy objects were sometimes transported using the “roller and sledge” method. The sledge was a platform placed on top of a number of round logs. As people dragged the sledge along, others continually moved the last roller to the front. It was hard work, but the load shifted.

Crosspiece holds the
planks together.

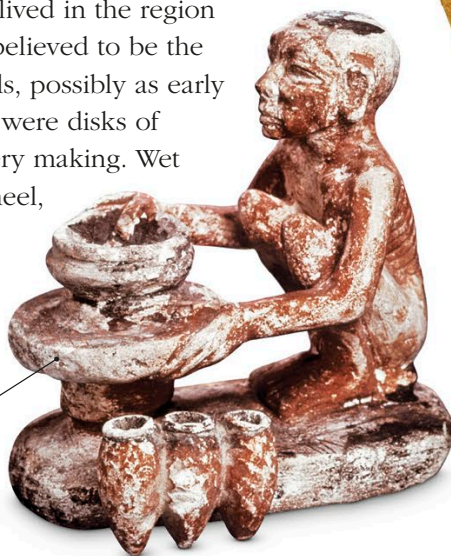


**Ancient Egyptian workers
moving a load to build pyramids**

POTTER'S WHEEL

The Mesopotamians, who lived in the region known today as Iraq, are believed to be the first people to make wheels, possibly as early as 5000 BCE. These wheels were disks of stone or clay used in pottery making. Wet clay was placed on the wheel, which was then turned by hand while the potter shaped the clay into pots or other vessels.

Wheel



**Ancient Egyptian
model of a potter**

